

Week 9 - Life in Nazi Germany:

Source 1 - Excerpts from Adolf Hitler's *Mein Kampf*

The whole organization of education, and training which the People's State is to build up must take as its crowning task the work of instilling into the hearts and brains of the youth entrusted to it the racial instinct and understanding of the racial idea. No boy or girl must leave school without having attained a clear insight into the meaning of racial purity and the importance of maintaining the racial blood unadulterated. Thus the first indispensable condition for the preservation of our race will have been established and thus the future cultural progress of our people will be assured.

A reform of particular importance is that which ought to take place in the present methods of teaching history. Scarcely any other people are made to study as much of history as the Germans, and scarcely any other people make such a bad use of their historical knowledge. If politics means history in the making, then our way of teaching history stands condemned by the way we have conducted our politics. But there would be no point in bewailing the lamentable results of our political conduct unless one is now determined to give our people a better political education. In 99 out of 100 cases the results of our present teaching of history are deplorable. Usually only a few dates, years of birth and names, remain in the memory, while a knowledge of the main and clearly defined lines of historical development is completely lacking. The essential features which are of real significance are not taught. It is left to the more or less bright intelligence of the individual to discover the inner motivating urge amid the mass of dates and chronological succession of events.

The subject matter of our historical teaching must be curtailed. The chief value of that teaching is to make the principal lines of historical development understood. The more our historical teaching is limited to this task, the more we may hope that it will turn out subsequently to be of advantage to the individual and, through the individual, to the community as a whole. For history must not be studied merely with a view to knowing what happened in the past but as a guide for the future, and to teach us what policy would be the best to follow for the preservation of our own people.

Source 2 - A German propaganda poster - 'Officer of tomorrow'



1. Compare and contrast the message of Source 1 and Source 2.

The message of Source 1 is that teaching and education should be reformed and that students should be taught the meaning of racial purity first and foremost. The source also states that the teaching of history in Germany has not been good enough and that it too must be overhauled and that 'history must not be studied merely with a view to knowing what happened in the past but as a guide for the future.' The message of Source 2 is that today's youth will be the 'Officer of tomorrow', implying that they should be educated with this in mind. The messages are similar as both relate to youth in Nazi Germany and the role of education or how young people should be taught. They both also talk about the need to prepare young people for the future. The messages are different in that Source 1 is more specific and emphasises the need to teach students the importance of racial purity and that history teaching has until now been very flawed, whereas, Source 2 merely states that today's Hitler Youth represents the 'Officer of tomorrow' but does not detail how young people will be transformed into those officers.

2. Identify and account for the author's perspective in Source 1 regarding the teaching of history.

The author of Source 1 is Adolf Hitler. His perspective regarding the teaching of history is that it had previously focused too much on simply remembering 'a few dates, years of birth and names', rather than on understanding how modern Germany historically developed. Hitler argues further that the teaching of history should be curtailed and that it should be limited to making 'the principal lines of historical development understood'.

Adolf Hitler was not a great student and mistrusted academics. He believed that all education should serve the purpose of teaching students the philosophies of National Socialism, chiefly that racial purity was paramount and that young people should be ready to serve the state. He believed that Germany had been led astray in recent years and that studying history should be limited to focusing on those that were responsible for Germany's demise and on past heroes that could inspire young people. This is why in Source 1 he argues that the teaching of history should essentially serve political means and should teach students the 'principal lines of historical development'.

3. Explain the purpose of Source 2.

The purpose of Source 2 is to inspire young boys and men to devote themselves to the state and glorify the idea of becoming an officer in the German Army. Source 2 is not a recruitment poster, however, it is a piece of propaganda that works much like one. It was produced to appeal to young boys and to glorify their future role in Nazi Germany and to encourage devotion to the state. In a sense it was also produced to normalize the idea that young people are the future warriors of Germany and should be prepared as such.